I. A GUIDELINE FOR WRITING A RESEARCH PROPOSAL

1. INTRODUCTION

From our experience, we have learnt that many students have difficulties in formatting their research proposals. This template is designed to assist you in writing your research. This template will serve as a starting point for any student writing a research proposal. The headings and styles give an indication of the sections required in the research proposal. The thesis proposal shall be typed in font 12, Times New Roman, 1.5 Space between lines, margin one by one inch (top, bottom, left and right), and justified alignment. It also consists of three major parts; namely: Preliminary, Body and Appendices. The word count for all contents shall not be more than 7,000.

The purpose of writing a proposal is to demonstrate that the topic addresses a significant problem; an organized plan to help solve the problem and methods should be identified and are appropriate. A secondary purpose of the proposal is to train you in the art of proposal writing. Any future career, whether it be in industry or academia will require these skills in some form. What we are interested in our students is a clear handle on the *process* and *structure* of research as it is practiced. If you can present a clear and reasonable thesis idea, clearly relate it to other relevant literature, justify its significance, describe a method for investigating it, and de-compose it into a sequence of steps that lead toward a reasonable conclusion, then the thesis proposal is a success regardless of whether you modify or even scrap the actual idea down the line and start off in a different direction. What a successful thesis proposal demonstrates is that, regardless of the eventual idea you pursue, you know the steps involved in turning it into a research paper.

2. STRUCTURE OF A PROPOSAL

Your proposal should have the following elements in order.

- Title page
- Table of contents
- Background of the study
- Statement of the Problem (Defining the problem, extent and severity of the problem, gap analysis)

- Objective of the study (major and specific objectives)
- Research Questions
- Hypothesis of the study
- Scope of the study
- Significance of the study
- Literature review (Theories, empirical works and conceptual framework)
- Methods of the study (Research design, model specification, data nature and source, estimation method and post estimation tests)
- Work plan (time and budget)
- List of references (APA Style)

Title page

- contains short, descriptive title of the proposed research (should be fairly self-explanatory), and
- author, institution, department, University, research supervisor, and date of delivery

Table of contents

- list all headings and subheadings with page numbers
- indent subheadings

Background

- Give an overview of the subject area. By way of introduction, this reading section of the existing literature should take the form of an abstract of the general subject or study area and identify the discipline(s) within which it falls.
- From this analysis the problem or disorder you wish to research will emerge and constitutes the reason or condition which necessitates the research.
- You should also indicate here the way in which your background gives you competencies in the chosen area.
- This section sets the context for your proposed project and must capture the reader's interest
- Explain the background of your study starting from a broad picture narrowing in on your research question
- Review what is known about your research topic as far as it is relevant to your thesis
- Cite relevant and current references
- The introduction should be at a level that makes it easy to understand for readers with a general science background
- This section explains the purpose of your proposed study

Research Problems

- This is where you explain the research problem and question.
- From the overview of the subject area follows the research problem, i.e. you have to identify the possible cause(s) of the disorder. This section states the problem that you are exploring.
- It must consist of or address five components: Defining the problem, showing the severity of the problem, showing the extent of the problem, showing the gap analysis, and then finally set the research questions.
- The research question is specific, concise, and clear. The research question can be expanded upon by stating sub-questions.
- Note: The difference between the research problem and research question is that the problem is broader, while the research question represents the “one question that you will answer at the end of your dissertation”.

Research Objectives

- This is the place where you have to describe the research aim as it relates to solving the uncertainty or burning question you are interested in.
- It should explicitly hint towards the contribution you want to make with the intended study.
- Need to set both major and specific objectives in a very harnessed way
- Specific objective should not go beyond the major objective even in using action words
- The research objective should be SMART (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevance and Time bound) in expositions
- Make sure that all specific objectives can be addressed and captured by the model you specify and the estimation method you employ in.

Research Questions

- A Research question is a statement that identifies the phenomenon to be studied.
- To develop a strong research question from your ideas, you should ask yourself these things:
    - Do I know the field and its literature well?
    - What are the important research questions in my field?
    - What areas need further exploration?
    - Could my study fill a gap? Lead to greater understanding?
    - Has a great deal of research already been conducted in this topic area?

- Has this study been done before? If so, is there room for improvement?
- Is the timing right for this question to be answered?
- Is it a hot topic, or is it becoming obsolete?
- Would funding sources be interested?
- If you are proposing a service program, is the target community interested?
- Most importantly, will my study have a significant impact on the field?

Hypothesis of the study

- *Hypotheses* are more specific predictions about the nature and direction of the relationship between two variables.
- Strong hypotheses have the following natures (give insight into a research question; are testable and measurable by the proposed experiments; spring logically from the experience)
- Normally, no more than three primary hypotheses should be proposed for a research study
- Make sure you provide a rationale for your hypotheses—where did they come from, and why are they strong?
- Make sure you provide alternative possibilities for the hypotheses that could be tested—why did you choose the ones you did over others?
- If you have good hypotheses, they will lead into your specific objectives. Specific objectives are the steps you are going to take to test your hypotheses and what you want to accomplish in the course of the research period. Make sure that your objectives are measurable and highly focused; each hypothesis is matched with a specific aim and make sure that the aims are feasible, given the time and money you are requesting in the grant.

Scope of the study

- It should be clearly stated
- There must be a clear boundary and scope in terms of time, issue and area of the study
- In this section, you will tell the reader what to be included and excluded from your study.

Significance of the study

- It refers to the merit of the research and proposed contribution to science
- A convincing statement is required as to why your topic merits scientific research, i.e. how it will contribute to and enrich the academic knowledge and understanding of economic theory and professional economic practice.
- This contribution results from the systematic investigation of your research activities, which are conducted to discover new information, as well as to expand and verify existing knowledge.

- This contribution does not simply imply the gathering of new data and a description thereof, i.e. the *what?* Questions. There are many things we do not know and that we could find out. This is data-gathering. The contribution to be made by research goes beyond this and requires the *so what?* Questions, i.e. explanations, relationships, generalisations and theories.

Literature review

- In this section, you should demonstrate that you are interested with the debates and issues raised in related literature.
- You should furnish a description of recent academic and empirical research in your chosen area.
- References to key texts and recently published articles should be made to convince that you appreciate their integrative relevance to your research area.
- Your research should be an original research and you should be able to demonstrate that your proposed area has not been studied before. As such, you need to identify how your own research might make a useful contribution to the particular economics-related area.
- You need compose three components of literature review: Theoretical literature review, Empirical Literature review, and then you need to develop conceptual framework
- Your conceptual framework should be an outcome both theoretical and empirical literatures and you need to draw how economic variables and issues are inter related one another, leading to identifying triggering and driving forces, transmission channels and interactions.

Research Methods

- Outline the methodology to be used. In its most widely-used description, research methodology relates to the nature of the scientific method used.
- You need to display an awareness of the available methodologies for data collection and show a clear understanding of the methodologies that would be most suitable for your research.
- It may be that qualitative methods are appropriate, e.g. case studies and group discussions.
- Alternatively, your research may involve quantitative aspects relating to statistics and economics. You need to select the appropriate proposed methodology.
- Since most studies are multi-disciplinary, they employ a combination of qualitative and quantitative research methodologies, which is called a hybrid approach.
- You are expected to outline the design you consider to be most appropriate, i.e. how the research would be conducted.
- Typically, reference is made here to the type of data you will need, the nature of data collection (questionnaire development, sampling, type of survey, etc.), processing and interpretation.
- Data collection: describe the data collection methods you will use.

- Data Analysis: describe your proposed data analysis approach and techniques.
- In general, it consists of research design, model specifications, data nature, sources, and state about eh chosen econometric estimation method

Work plan

- You need to include a preliminary time and work schedule outlining the main phases in your research project. This is referred to as the research protocol.
- describe in detail what you plan to do until completion of your research paper
- list the stages of your research paper in a table format
- indicate deadlines you have set for completing each stage of the project, including any work you have already completed
- discuss any particular challenges that need to be overcome

List of references

- The most important thing regarding references is that you should start recording all details of your references from the first day you start your research.
- It is impossible to try and find details, such as page numbers and volume numbers, when you compile your final reference list months later.
- Rather keep more details than you think you will need.
- Cite all ideas, concepts, text, data that are not your own
- If you make a statement, back it up with your own data or a reference
- All references cited in the text must be listed
- Cite single-author references by the surname of the author (followed by date of the publication in parenthesis)
- Cite double-author references by the surnames of both authors (followed by date of the publication in parenthesis)
- Cite more than double-author references by the surname of the first author followed by et al. and then the date of the publication
- List all references cited in the text in alphabetical order
- Follow the chosen style of bibliography if set by the University

Technical Specifications

1. Type of headings

- This guideline limits you to four numbers in the heading at most
- Use the tool to paint headings of the same level or select the same type of heading from the list of Styles.
- Here are the names of the headings:
- For main topic heading use (left aligned, bold, upper case 1. heading); for sub topic headings, use (left aligned, bold, upper case 1.1 heading) and so on

2. Page Layout

- The general page layout of your research proposal should be an A4-size page with 0.5 inch margins on all sides.
- Times New Roman is the preferred font.
- The title and chapter headings are in 14-point Times New Roman Bold. The other headings and body text are in 12 point Times New Roman.

Grammar/spelling

- Poor grammar and spelling distract from the content of the proposal. The reader focuses on the grammar and spelling problems and misses keys points made in the text. Modern word processing programs have grammar and spell checkers. Use them.
- Read your proposal aloud - then have a friend read it aloud. If your sentences seem too long, make two or three sentences instead of one. Try to write the same way that you speak when you are explaining a concept. Most people speak more clearly than they write.
- You should have read your proposal over at least 5 times before handing it in
- Simple wording is generally better
- If you get comments from others that seem completely irrelevant to you, your paper is not written clearly enough never use a complex word if a simpler word will do

Plagiarism Checking:

- You should not use in your papers and thesis materials from other sources without citing them. For example, if any paragraph is taken directly from any journal, you should provide the exact citation (word by word), then the direct quotation must be inserted into quotation marks and the citation must be linked to the exact material used.
- The same is effective for translations: if you translate word by word, it is a direct citation (quotation marks and a link to the used exact source are required).
- It is not sufficient to list sources at the end of your paper or thesis only if a direct quotation is used.
- If you use only ideas, not the wording from a source, you should list the source at the end, but you should introduce the idea by a number of the source in square brackets according to the list of sources, or you should provide the name of author with the year of publication or you can only state that the authors name whose idea is used.

II. A GUIDELINE FOR PREPARING POWERPOINT

One of the most common mistakes in creating a presentation is to place too much information on the screen. This can cause the reader to become distracted from the speaker. Audiences are much more receptive to the spoken word. Keep it simple: Make bulleted points easy to read, keep text easy to understand, Use concise wording, bullets are focal points, presenter provides elaboration and keep font size large. Top twelve rules for creating a PowerPoint presentation

1. Remember that you are the presenter, not the PowerPoint. Use your slides to emphasize a point, keep yourself on track, and don’t read the slides.
2. Don’t make your audience read the slides either. Keep text to a minimum (6-8 lines per slide, no more than 30 words per slide). The bullet points should be headlines, not news articles. Write in sentence fragments using key words, and keep your font size 24 or bigger.
3. Make sure your presentation is easy on the eyes. Stay away from weird colours and busy backgrounds. Use easy-to-read fonts such as Times New Roman for the bulk of your text, and, if you have to use a funky font, use it sparingly.
4. Never include anything that makes you announce, “I don’t know if everyone can read this, but….” Make sure they can read it before you begin. Print out all your slides on standard paper, and drop them to the floor. The slides are probably readable if you can read them while you’re standing.
5. Leave out the sound effects and background music, unless it’s related to the content being presented. If you haven’t made arrangements with the coordinator before your presentation, your audience members might not be able to hear your sound effects anyway. The same goes for animated graphics and imbedded movie files. Your sounds and animated graphics will not be functional on the synchronized version of your webcast.
6. Sure you can make the words boomerang onto the slide, but you don’t have to. Stick with simple animations if you use them at all. Remember that some of your audience may have learning disabilities such as dyslexia, and swirling words can be a tough challenge. These animations will not be functional in the webcast version.
7. Proofread, proofread, proof read. You’d hate to discover that you misspelled your name during your presentation in front of people, with your examiners in the front row.
8. Practice, practice, practice. The more times you go through the presentation, the less you’ll have to rely on the slides for cues and the smoother your presentation will be. PowerPoint software allows you to make notes on each slide, and you can print out the notes versions if you need help with pronunciations or remembering what comes next.
9. Using the rule of thumb that it takes about 10 minutes to present all slides, you have just enough time to present 15 slides effectively.
10. Capitalizing the first word, generally, left-justify bullets, avoid All Caps – Very Hard To Read, stay away from gimmicky fonts unless for a theme, use bold when you want some words to stand out and avoid text overload.

11. Use a color of font that contrasts sharply with the background. Using color for decoration is distracting and annoying.
12. Use the same background consistently throughout your presentation

III. A GUIDELINE FOR PRESENTATION

If you wish your ideas to be understood and to have an impact, you must be able to communicate effectively. Quite often students make unclear and incoherent talks, which are difficult to follow, untidy, full of errors, and delivered with no evident practice. Such talks are ineffective for communication and show their presenters in the worst possible light. Again, if you wish your ideas to be understood — and if you wish your peers to think highly of you — you must be able to communicate effectively.

Preparing the presentation:

- Organization: Your presentation will be most effective when the audience walks away understanding the five things any listener to a presentation really cares about: What is the problem, and why is it a problem? What have others done about it? What are you doing about it? What value does your approach add? Where do we go from here? What are the methods and what are the findings?
- The proposal presentation: Your presentation should be about 10 minutes long and should concentrate on your findings and recommendations. A sample outline of your presentation might contain: Statement of the problem (2 minutes), goal/objectives of the research (2 min), literature review/theoretical framework (3 min), methodology (4min).
- Carefully budget your time, especially for short presentations: Allow enough time to describe the problem clearly. Leave enough time to present your own contribution clearly. This almost never will require all of the allotted time. Leave time for questions. If your talk is done well, it will stimulate questions from the audience, often from senior people who are intrigued by your work and wish to learn more about it. With the tight schedules, a question period is often left to the end or omitted entirely, effectively making this form of interchange impossible.
- Timing your talk few things irritate an audience more than a 30-minute talk. Delivered in 15 minutes. Your objective is to engage the audience and have them understand your message. Don’t flood them with more than they can absorb. This means:
    - Present only as much material as can reasonably fit into the time allotted. Generally, that means no more than 1 slide per minute.
    - Talk at a pace that everybody in the audience can understand. Speak slowly, clearly, and loudly.
    - PRACTICE, PRACTICE, PRACTICE. Ask a colleague to judge your presentation, delivery, clarity of language, and use of time.

Balance the amount of material you present with a reasonable pace of presentation. If you feel rushed when you practice, then you have too much material. Budget your time to take a minute or two less than your maximum allotment. Speakers at defence often go a few minutes over their allotted time. In most cases, this is harmless. At professional conferences, however, it is essential that all speakers start and end on time. Nothing is more frustrating to the last speaker in a session than to watch the second-last speaker go five minutes over; that is five minutes stolen, and there is no getting it back. If you are chairing a session, enforce time limits strictly; if you are speaking, defer to the chair when he signals that your time is up.

The presentation: Never apologize for your slides. More to the point make apologies unnecessary by creating clear, understandable slides in the first place. If you say, "I know you can’t see this, but ..." the reaction of many people in the audience will be “then why bother showing it?”. Don’t apologize for incomplete results. People understand that research is a continuing process. Just present the results and let the audience judge. It is OK to say that “work is ongoing”. If you say “I’m sorry that work is not done”, you invite the audience to tune out or wonder why you are talking at all. If, despite your best efforts, you find that you have taken more time than anticipated, it is better to skip whole sections of your talk than to try to squeeze five minutes of material into two. For example, people will take your word for it that simulation results came out as expected. Just say that; rushing through the slides does not make things better.